

## Introduction

# POST-, GRAND, CLASSICAL OR “SO-CALLED”: WHAT IS, AND WAS, FILM THEORY?

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Today, film theory is at a crossroad. On the one hand, its body of concepts is growing thanks to the emergence of new perspectives and new situations to be taken into account. On the other hand, some of its traditional keywords are being strongly criticized, especially by the exponents of the so-called philosophy of film, because of their alleged inconsistency and inefficacy.

The growth of theory responds to a multifold impulse. First of all, the process of digitalization and media convergence, with their huge impact on film, urge theory to reckon with new questions and to dialogue with other disciplines equally interested in the same facts. The increasing use of new devices and platforms, from computers to smart-phones and to headsets like Oculus Rift, changes our perspectives on the film apparatus and recalls aspects that are more familiar to media studies. Film's migration into domestic spaces, urban squares or theme parks calls for an ecological sensibility that was formerly largely unknown in the field (although the configuration of movie theatres could have certainly already suggested that cinema is an environmental art). The development of new forms of vision, from 3-D to virtual reality, reshapes our approach to film reception and asks for a wider attention to processes that are currently undertaken by neurosciences. Film theory confronts unprecedented situations and adjusts its own methods and goals. As a consequence, it shares with other disciplines concepts like digitization, scale, network, hybridity, cybernetics, embodied cognition and the Anthropocene.<sup>1</sup>

At the same time, the availability of never-explored archives provides the opportunity to gain a better grasp on the topics discussed in the past. This is true for the Western canon: one thinks of Abel (1988), an anthology on the first wave of French film theory, Andel and Szczepanik (2008), a collection of early Czech film theory, and more recently, Kaes, Baer and Cowan (2016), an anthology of German film theory until 1933. It is equally true for traditions that fall outside of it, as shown by current explorations of early Asian debates by Nornes and Gerow (2009), Bao (2015) and Fan (2015), which provide a much better sense of the issues at stake in the field and their transnational circulation. This archival work elicits a global reconsideration of film theory: the latter not only discovers the wealth of its lineages, but is also encouraged to reread its canonical texts<sup>2</sup>beyond the borders of an aesthetic approach still persistent in some reconstructions (see Rodowick 2014).<sup>3</sup>

Film theory flourishes, either in retracing its own past or in facing cinema's future. And yet it is under attack. A group of scholars, predominantly Anglo-American, and generally followers of the analytical philosophy, claim that most of the concepts that film theory uses are weak, inaccurate and groundless. They lack internal coherence and they do not appropriately explain how cinema works. Hence, such scholars claim, we need a philosophical approach that can offer both a rigorous scrutiny and a redefinition of the traditional issues.<sup>4</sup> There is no doubt that the presence of a sort of meta-theory, aimed at questioning the nature and the basis of what we usually call film theory, is extremely useful.<sup>5</sup> Many concepts have been, and are, merely the outcome of fashionable approaches. Unfortunately, in opposition to a tradition that saw the Italian philosopher Giovanni Papini, praised by

William James in 1907 for his polemical flair, ask the cinema to infuse philosophy with its own questions and philosophy to respond with its full competence (see Papini 2017), the “new” philosophers of film tend to interpret their task in a prevalent antagonistic mode. Concepts under scrutiny are generally dismantled and often dismissed, and when redefined, it is in a new light, often alien to their history. The consequence is an attempt—often unexpressed—to legitimize film philosophy as a discipline that overrules and supersedes film theory: as if the former were able to provide a “truth” that the latter cannot completely attain.

But what is the “truth” of a theory? The exactness of its concepts or the necessity that makes them appear? Its internal coherence or the very fact that it is an answer to an emerging question? The “truth” of film theories—as for literary, theatrical or artistic theories, so different from scientific ones—is deeply connected with their endless attempt to move “toward” their object with steps that are always reflecting the spirit of the time; in this sense their “truth” overlaps with their historical significance and effectiveness. Formal scrutiny of their claims fails to grasp their core. Put in another way, discourses are “events,” as Foucault used to say;<sup>6</sup> they occur at one moment and at one place, and they respond to rules of construction that change over time. An analysis outside their context risks misunderstanding them—or not capturing their potentiality. Film theories are no exception: they are discourses that respond to the pressure of their time, and we can grasp them only in the force-field in which they move.<sup>7</sup>

It is in this vein that I’d like to propose a reconsideration of what we intend by *film theory*. If we assume (again, with Foucault 1972) that film theories are also “discursive formations” that keep together a variety of statements otherwise dispersed, then we can detect under the same term at least four different kinds of aggregation, each of them emerging in a distinct period, making a distinct array of connections, obeying a distinct set of rules, aiming at distinct tasks, and, inevitably, swiveling on a distinct idea of “truth.” Film theory is not one; historically speaking, it is at least a fourfold reality that reflects different styles of thought.

The first contributions with a “theoretical” ambition appeared around 1907, in coincidence with the stabilization of cinema as theatrical spectacle. I put the term between quotation marks: indeed, early “theories” do not possess those characteristics to which the great reflections on film from the mid-1920s onward have accustomed us. For example, they do not develop from systematic work carried out in books and essays. Instead, they are usually sporadic interventions, related to current events or cultural polemics, and are printed in daily newspapers, promotional journals, illustrated papers and works of fiction. Trade journals have sometimes organized more focused debates: in the United States *The Moving Picture World* offered ongoing considerations about cinema’s social role and critics’ duties. And yet only in the mid-1910s do we find book-long reflections that try to study in depth one or another aspect of a multifaceted phenomenon. The authors of these early interventions were not individuals whose research dealt entirely or even predominantly with cinema; rather, they were often journalists, intellectuals or writers on a wide variety of subjects, for whom cinema was only one of many interests. Again, we find exceptions: Thomas Bedding, Stephen W. Bush and Louis Reeves Harrison in the United States or Ricciotto Canudo and later Louis Delluc in Europe, were *film* critics; but the bulk of debate was constituted by contributions from nonspecialized individuals. There was not a “discipline” as a frame of reference that clearly outlined how and why cinema should be examined; instead contributions responded to a range of different motivations, from simple curiosity about a recent invention to observations of the effects that films have upon social life. Finally, this discursive production did not often call itself theory, and when it did, it was not without reticence. Such is the case with Victor Oscar Freeburg, who in 1918 claimed for himself the “role of theorist and philosopher,” and at the same time recognized the primacy of producers in dealing with cinema

(Freeburg 1918, 263), as well as with Arturo Sebastiano Luciani, who in 1919 assigned theoretical status to his ruminations, and at the same time acknowledged that they can raise suspicion—a suspicion that he tried to dissolve by practically incorporating his ideas in a sample of film script inspired by Judith’s story (Luciani 1919, 2).<sup>8</sup>

The four characteristics of early film “theories”—their sporadic occurrence, quasi-anonymous writers, lack of a clear “method,” and hesitation toward self-identification—find their roots in the main question that these discourses had to deal with: in short, they shared the need to provide an image of cinema that facilitated its social comprehension and acceptance. Cinema at first sight appears a puzzling and even a scandalous fact. How can one grasp an apparatus that seems to capture the fleeting moment and ensure the permanence of life? How can one justify a machine with a gaze that goes beyond human capacities? How can one adapt to something that glorifies ubiquity, simultaneity, speed and details? And how can the enormous success of cinema be explained? The early “theories” respond to the demand for a practical and shared definition of a phenomenon that seems to challenge our expectations and our habits. In this sense, early “film theories” are similar to those personal *accounts* that we formulate to make sense of our daily actions, and that ethnomethodology describes as a key component of our social lives (see Garfinkel 1967). Accounts epitomize the ways members of a community signify, describe or explain the properties of a specific social situation in order to clarify and share its meaning. Likewise, early theories seek to make what at first might appear ambiguous and strange into something comprehensible and graspable: they show what cinema is and how we encounter it, what distinguishes it and how we can react to it, what it can offer us and why we must accept it. The result of all of this is a “public image” of cinema, which functions to both define and legitimate.

I want to add that early film “theories” also had a dark side. Not all the accounts were aimed at making film an acceptable object; there was no lack of negative interpretations and disqualifying assessments. As a counterpart of a “cinephiliac theory,” we can find a cinephobia that tries to display its own reasons (see e.g., the Kinoreform section in Kaes, Baer and Cowan 2016).

In the mid-1920s, we have the gradual emergence of a new “discursive formation.” What takes shape is the so-called classical film theory. A turning point is the extremely influential *Visible Man* by Béla Balázs, originally published in 1924 (Balázs 2010). According to Balázs, film is an already established reality; its relevance makes it worthy of a deeper investigation. But aestheticians are lazy in welcoming new objects into the precinct of art, hence the need to create a new field of investigation. Film theory is such a new field. Its first task is “to explore film’s *possibility in principle*”; consequently, it can move forward “by fixing on definite goals and calculating all their implications,” and finally it can test “the pathways leading to these goals” (Balázs 2010, 5 and 6 respectively). Hence the great metaphors that Balázs uses to define theory: “It is the road map for those who roam among the arts, showing them pathways and opportunities”; or “[it] is, if not the rudder, then at least the compass of an artistic trend” (Balázs 2010, 3 and 5 respectively).

Six years later, Rudolph Arnheim, with his even more influential *Film* (often read and quoted in the amended and less interesting version of 1957, even though the original was immediately translated into English: see Arnheim 1933) performs a more radical move: instead of highlighting the elements that make cinema a relevant art, like the revitalization of our visual skills, the presence of close-ups and the representation of landscape, he directly focuses on the rules that govern film. Arnheim starts from an axiom: “In order that the film artist may create a work of art it is most important that he should consciously stress the peculiarity of its medium.” (Arnheim 1933, 46). The medium of cinema finds its peculiarity in its ability to perfectly reproduce an object, yet transform it in a purely visual representation. Hence a second axiom: “It is due to divergencies between film picture and nature that

it is possible for a work of art to emerge from a film camera.” (Arnheim 1933, 46). From these two axioms stems a full array of norms that define an appropriate and effective film practice. As a consequence, what in Balázs was the map or the compass orienting film practice and criticism, in Arnheim becomes the rule of law that leads toward a correct film-making and a consistent film appreciation.

The main characteristics of classical film theory largely stem from this new orientation. First, theory is a foundational discourse: its purpose is to provide the “principles” on which the new art is based—the “specificity” that it obeys. Second, debate becomes more systematic: it is now centered on few well-defined issues to be explored. Third, theory is a recognizable field of research, different from personal accounts or simple reviews. Fourth, the function of legitimizing cinema as art is addressed not to public opinion, but to the intellectuals who can appreciate its basic norms and its inner way of working: theory is a business for specialists. However paradoxical it may seem, the great contributions of the 1940s and 1950s, notably André Bazin’s (2005, originally 1958) and Edgar Morin’s (2005, originally 1956), also follow this line. There are key elements that define cinema as such (the restitution of the real in Bazin, the creation of an imaginary in Morin); there is a net of concepts that sustains the basic ideas (in Bazin, the redefinition of film language in “indexical” terms; in Morin, its redefinition in terms of a “reason”); and there are methods of reading films that develop in cine-clubs (Bazin) or in academic environments (Morin).

I just add two remarks. Classical film theory takes advantage of the long-lasting period of stability that film has enjoyed between the end of 1910s and the end of 1960s. Despite some occasional variation, film’s modes of representation—as well as its modes of production—are steady, and taken as intrinsically characteristic of cinema. Film theorists can analyze them as they were film’s essence, when, as Jonathan Crary states, “what were most often identified as essential were temporary elements of larger constellations whose rates of change were variable and unpredictable” (Crary 2013, 38). Second, at the core of classical theory, undoubtedly there is an aesthetic concern. Yet, there is no lack of different interests. For example, Bazin and, even more, Morin display a persistent anthropological background. Classical theory looks compact, but it is far from being immobile.

At the beginning of the 1970s, a new “discursive formation” appears. It is the well-known Grand Theory, as Bordwell and Carroll (1996) call it with utmost contempt.<sup>9</sup> Without going into details, suffice it to say that Grand Theory is underpinned by a twofold aspiration. Through the convergence of three main fields of reference—semiotics, psychoanalysis and Marxism—it wants to provide a unified framework for interpreting cinema’s way of working in connection with the rules that govern language, the inner psychic processes and the general mode of commodities production. And through a deconstruction of cinema’s way of working, it aims at unfolding its ideological consequences—including the fact that spectators perceive on the screen a representation as if it were reality and follow the represented events as if they were mastering them.

In a certain sense, Grand Theory does not deflect from the path already traced: there is a set of axioms and their application to film at large. Yet the trajectory looks unidirectional: instead of asking theory to explore and evaluate a wide set of occurrences, now a scheme is applied without distinction. In this sense, Bordwell’s and Carroll’s critique—Grand Theory had come to be characterized by ambition, abstraction and ambiguity—sounds reasonable. What they miss is the context (or, better, they reduce the context to a French–American rivalry): if early “theories” reflected an epoch of novelty and classical theory an epoch of institutionalization, then Grand Theory responds to an epoch of film’s supposed omnipotence, the sense that Hollywood mode of production dominates cinema and that cinema dominates our culture in its inner fibers. Hence Grand Theory’s obsession with providing a conceptual framework able to orchestrate a critical response to an alleged massive attack, everywhere and anytime. Grand Theory’s original sin is not its arrogance; it is its paranoia.

Once again, two remarks. The fear of film's omnipotence is nevertheless productive: if it takes a paranoid connotation in Baudry (1976 and 1986) or in a journal like *Cinéthique*, then it also elicits concepts that are crucial, starting from the ideas of subject position and film apparatus. In this vein, we are still indebted with the way in which Mulvey (1975) unfolds the dialectics between the pleasure that film gifts us and the trap in which it frames or with the way in which Metz (1982) explores the complicity between film's procedures and our psychic processes. Second, such a fear of film's omnipotence emerges in the wrong moment: at the beginning of the 1960s, Hollywood is in distress, and other media are taking the lead. The Grand Theory—as well as its critics—do not perceive that enemy, if there is one, is elsewhere. The paranoia is misplaced.

What Bordwell and Carroll hail in their condemnation is the advent of another kind of film theory based on small-scale research and more rigorous procedure. A piecemeal theory that drops excessive ambitions is seen as fruitful.<sup>10</sup> The request for such a new form of theorizing responds to a desire of control: scholars must avoid concepts that lack of solid foundation; they must abstain from explications referring to an overly wide range of phenomena; and they must follow rigorous procedures of verification. In this sense the new approach is far from being a natural or innocent choice: it largely depends on the ideal of natural sciences—and yet an ideal that at the time was criticized by different branches of epistemology, including the so-called epistemological anarchism (see Feyerabend 1975), and that collides with the recurring attempt to develop theories that encompass different fields. In any case, according Bordwell and Carroll, research must be limited and practical. Theory (with capital T) must cede its place to a post-theory.

During the 1990s and 2000s, post-theory was rampant. However, the landscape was far from being homogeneous: there was a new discipline, cognitive psychology, that tried to take the lead, but there were also active discourses still indebted to Grand Theory and its filiations (including parts of gender studies), as well as approaches that resumed a sort of “ontological” orientation, as most of the contributions about the advent of digital would do, for reasons of their claim that the end of the indexical image is the end of cinema. In a sense Bordwell and Carroll's program ends up in a marketplace where everyone can find the commodity she likes. In the spirit of a perfect neoliberal age, film theory too becomes a shopping mall. And yet, this chaotic situation (a theory of Babel ...) is what makes possible the extensions, contaminations and innovations that theory enjoys nowadays.

It should be a mistake to consider film “theories” (between quotation marks), classical film theory, Grand Theory and post-theory as “discursive formations” belonging to the past. History is not necessarily a sequence of events in which the newer buries the older: it is not even a chronological chain, but a set of relations in which there is an endless back and forth between past and present.<sup>11</sup> This is peculiarly true for these different stages of film theory: they leave behind them a sort of wake whose waves are breaking on our shores. It is not by chance that many of their key words are still in use in film studies: our current vocabulary is deeply indebted to them. In this sense, the film theory that we are practicing nowadays is a field that lies on four geological strata; or, if you prefer, a four-layered cake that we must eat appreciating its many flavors (the flavor of theory is something that Balázs already noticed).<sup>12</sup> The book that my few pages are intended to preface would reflect this configuration of the field, with keywords that emerged in different stages, sometimes in the far past, sometimes as recent eruptions, but both displaying their potentialities in the present. I like to imagine it as a tectonic book.

Why reconsider film theory and make use of it for contemporary needs? How can certain concepts be retained and revived? If “theories” between quotation marks faced a novelty, if classical theory confronted an institutionalization, if Grand Theory responded to a fear, if post-theory established a free market of methods, then today the challenge comes from a dilemma. Is the deep transformation

that cinema is experiencing a way to preserve its identity and to rediscover its possibilities or a step toward its dissolution into a wider landscape? I am supportive of the first hypothesis (Casetti 2015), but the second should not be excluded: going beyond its usual extent or even trying to reboot itself, cinema can collapse.

The aforementioned growth of the conceptual body that today characterizes film theory reflects this dilemma: our vocabulary recaptures concepts that frame what film could be or would have been and at the same time encapsulates concepts that belong to other disciplines. It is the case with the three main trends that characterize film studies nowadays: a neo-aesthetics, often indebted with philosophers like Deleuze or Rancière, that focuses on cinema as a special region of Art or Thought; a reconsideration of spectator's sensorial and affective activity, often tied with neuro-sciences; and an interest in the place of cinema within media landscapes and physical territories, tuned with environmental studies. The result is reassuring and alarming at once—reassuring in safeguarding a field whose borders are increasingly porous, and alarming in a concession to the vantage points of competing approaches. Theory's expansion—like film's—can become a dispersion.

The impulse for a meta-theory echoes the same dilemma. No doubt that a critical scrutiny of theory's vocabulary can be extremely useful: it can offer the opportunity to understand concepts' resilience and endurance. In this sense, it is a contribution to make the field wider, but also solid and tuned with the current situation.<sup>13</sup> Yet no test comes without a price. If the scrutiny becomes a systematic revision, if the stratification of concepts is dropped, then the “cleansed” vocabulary risks no longer speaking film theory's language. In this case, the operation is an involuntary contribution to the dismissal of film and its history from our present. A redefinition becomes a foreclosure.

Cinema's uncertain destiny puts theory under stress, but it also allows the theory to acquire an agility it has never had before. Theory can fully become what it has always been: an endless Penelope's web, ceaselessly made and remade but always aimed at one goal, to capture film's nature. Cinema still needs discourses able to understand and explain its own presence. Its present status amplifies this request—and makes its query even more worthy.

## Notes

- 1 A contribution widely representative of the problems and concepts raised by post-cinema is Shaw and Weibel (2003).
- 2 An impulse to reread canonical texts comes, among others, from the special issues of two journals: “A Return to Classical Film Theory?” *October* 148 (Spring 2014); and “What's New in Classical Film Theory?” *Screen* 55, no. 3 (Autumn 2014).
- 3 Rodowick's is an extremely useful and influential contribution, and yet, it narrows film theory to an aesthetically based discourse. My claim here is that film theory, including the classical film theory, was not exclusively an aesthetic discourse.
- 4 At the origin of this movement is Carroll (1988a and 1988b); see also Allen-Smith (1997) (in particular the “manifesto” by Gregory Currie, “The Theory That Never Was: A Nervous Manifesto”).
- 5 “One of the characteristics of philosophy as a discipline is its questioning of its own nature and basis. The philosophy of film shares this characteristic with the field in general. Indeed, a first issue that the philosophy of film must address is the grounds for its own existence. This involves not only the question of what the field should look like, but also that of whether it has any reason to exist at all.” (Wartenberg 2015).
- 6 See in particular Foucault (1972).
- 7 On the historical nature of film theory, see the Niemeyer and Hochscherf (2016) and the special issue of *Historical Journal of Film, Radio and Television* that they edit.

- 8 For the ambivalent attitude toward theory until the 1920s, see also Seldes (1924). And yet there is no lack of clear praises: suffice it to recall what Vachel Lindsay states: “Somewhere in this enormous field, piled with endowments mountain high, it should be possible to establish the theory and practice of the photoplay as a fine art.” (Lindsay 1922, 30). By the end of the 1920s the term will become a shared currency.
- 9 Most of the criticism expressed in Bordwell and Carroll (1996) is anticipated in Carroll (1988a). The term Grand Theory is borrowed—consciously or unconsciously—from *The Sociological Imagination* by C. Wright Mills (1959) where it designates “a systematic theory of the nature of man and society” as expressed in particular by Talcott Parsons.
- 10 “Currently, then, we are in need of piecemeal theorizing, in need of theories about film rather than Film Theory. [...] Perhaps some of the fruits of our piecemeal theories will be organizable into larger, systematic and theoretical constellations.” (Carroll 1988a, 232). Žižek (2001) would ironize about the modesty of the Carroll’s and Bordwell’s “modest proposal.”
- 11 Benjamin’s “dialectical image” captures precisely this back and forth between the past and the now. See Benjamin (1999), in particular Section N.
- 12 “Aesthetic theory is nothing more than a thoughtful savouring in the attempt to feel and enjoy the hidden product of an inner life.” (Balázs 2010, 7).
- 13 Malcolm Turvey often underscores the claim that keywords need not only to display their glorious past, but also to confirm their current convenience: see for example the “Roundtable on the Return to Classical Film Theory” in the aforementioned special issue of October (Spring 2014, pp. 5–26) and his recent “Epstein, Sound, and the Return to Classical Film Theory,” *Mise au point*, 8, 2016, URL: <http://map.revues.org/2039>.

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